

ROLE PLAY A scene from *Letters of Suresh*

In the last decade, Feroz Abbas Khan has become the S.S. Rajamouli or Sanjay Leela Bhansali of the stage. With musicals like *Mughal-e-Azam*, *Raunaq & Jassi* and *Civilization to Nation*—the production which marked the launch of the Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre (NMACC) in Mumbai—which are big on scale and spectacle and incorporate varied performing arts, Khan has made theatre more accessible. It wasn't a "conscious decision", says Khan, to anchor a ship of 100-plus cast and crew day in and day out, but doing so did necessitate a "yearning". "When it comes to pure theatre, my *parvarish* [foundation], where I feel most comfortable is the minimum," he says. "Going to the purest form of language and performance...that's the power of theatre."

From May 9-12 at the NMACC, Khan practices what he preaches as he adapts Indian-American playwright and Pulitzer Prize finalist Rajiv Joseph's drama, *Letters of Suresh*. A play composed entirely of letters which features four actors performing a series of monologues, it sees Khan hark back to his roots which resulted in plays like *Tumhari Amrita*, *Salesman Ramlal*, *Gandhi vs Gandhi* and *Saalgirah*. Marking the stage debut of Vir Hirani, son of filmmaker Rajkumar Hirani, the play will enjoy a run at Prithvi Theatre after a few months.

It was while *Mughal-e-Azam* was running at the prestigious Lincoln Theatre in New York last year that Khan got an opportunity to meet Joseph. Not to be un-

MUSIC

THE GREAT DISRUPTOR

Rapper SlowCheeta is trying to shake things up with his EP, ***Scene Mein Bawaal***

April was a busy time for rapper and actor SlowCheeta aka Chaitnya Sharma. Last month saw the release of the sports drama ***Maidaan***, in which he played legendary Indian footballer P.K. Banerjee, as well as his sophomore EP, *Scene Mein Bawaal*. Both projects had been in the making for three years, but SlowCheeta didn't work on them simultaneously because he consciously keeps his two careers separate. "I would not like to be writing an EP while doing a film and vice versa," says the 33-year-old MC signed to INCINK Records, the music label co-founded by actor Ranveer Singh. "It seems a bit disloyal to one if I do something else at the same time".

SlowCheeta candidly admits that he waited to put out *Scene Mein Bawaal*, and the Singh-featuring video for focus track '*Kar De Kaa?*', after *Maidaan* opened at the box office in order to capitalise on the attention he would get from the big-budget Bollywood production.

Now that the film is out, he's shifted his focus to promoting the EP, which is based around the idea of taking listeners through "every emotion" you experience when taking a particular step. "It could be something as silly as starting a workout or something as deep as hugging your father after 20 years," he says.

On the dance-friendly '*Kar De Kaa?*', SlowCheeta playfully asks his audience whether he should go ahead with a plan. Next we hear him chopping—a form of super-fast rapping—on 'Maniac', which represents the phase when you overthink the decision. It's followed by the galloping '*Chaaku Bhonk*', which aims to capture the confidence you eventually gain to finally execute it, and party

